The Photographer's Guide to Posing

Techniques for Flattering Your Subjects

Shot #1

✗ Problems (Figure 12.19)

Mergers: The arm on the left of the frame is tight against the subject's body, creating a merger that makes her appear wide.

Hand: Her hand is in an awkward position, pointing at the camera.

Hips: Her hips are very broad and square to the camera, making her look wider.

Chin: Her chin is too neutral, so the jawline is not as defined as is desirable.

Posture: The subject is subtly leaning back away from the camera, making her head appear smaller and neck appear shorter.

Camera Angle: The camera angle is approximately even with her midsection—quite low in the frame.

Figure 12.19 annotations:

- *Merger: arm merged to body, making her look wider*
- *Hips: too broad/square to camera*
- *Hand: somewhat awkward*

✓ Solutions (Figures 12.20, 12.21, and 12.22)

Mergers: By placing her left hand on her hip, we've created negative space between the arm and the body, which now flatters the form.

Hand: The right hand is in a much more natural and comfortable position.

Hips: The hips are turned slightly away from the camera, making them appear narrower.

Chin: The subject has a more defined jawline, with the chin out and down.

Posture: The subject has improved posture and is leaning toward the camera.

Camera Angle: The camera angle is slightly higher. Combined with the subject's lean forward, there is now more attention to the face and bust, instead of to the midsection.

This shot is successful with multiple crops, whether it is a tight close-up, a mid-length shot, or a full-length shot. This full-length image creates strong, powerful, and flattering lines for the subject. The strong angles communicate the subject's strength, which is reflected by the bold choice of clothing and dramatic hair and makeup. With a softer outfit or more demure subject, I may have selected a curvier, gentler pose. This image, however, is all about her strength. Always ask yourself: What is this image about? Are all the pieces—lighting, posing, styling, color—working together to express the purpose?

When examining the final, retouched shots side by side (Figures 12.21 and 12.22), notable changes include: the left side of the jacket along the body is smoother—its original bulge was making the subject look wider, corrected using the Liquify filter in Photoshop. You will also notice changes in the shoulder area and overall silhouette.

Shot #2

✗ Problems (Figure 12.23)

Mergers: One arm is tight to the body, making her body appear wider.

Foreshortening: The arm on the chair appears drastically foreshortened with no forearm visible.

Posture: The subject is slouching, essentially falling into her shoulders, which raises the shoulders and shortens the neck.

Shape: The body is too square to the camera and appears at its widest angle.

Figure 12.23 annotations:

- *Mergers: arm against body, making it appear wider*
- *Foreshortening: forearm straight toward camera*
- *Shape: body too square to camera (appears wider)*

✓ Solutions (Figure 12.24)

Merger: Although one arm is still close to the body, the bend in the arms works to create the illusion of a waist because the arms meet across the body at the natural waist.

Shape: Her body has been rotated away from the camera. This helps to narrow her frame, including her legs and midsection.

Foreshortening: Her arm has been turned in, eliminating the foreshortening.

Narrowing Point: Her thighs have been posed in a way that creates a narrowing point at the knees.

Posture: The posture has been improved. The neck looks longer and the chin more defined.

Shot #3

✗ Problems (Figure 12.25)

(Content from Figure 12.25 continues beyond the captured screenshots.)

Source: The Photographer's Guide to Posing: Techniques to Flatter Everyone